

The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · For the executive steering committees at the public shipyards and SRF-JRMC

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Written this week for the executive steering committees at the four public shipyards and SRF-JRMC, which means the test for every item is whether it changes a strategic or business planning assumption rather than whether it is interesting. Four things clear that bar. The Navy opened the market for a dry dock program at Puget Sound with a ceiling of \$30 billion, which concentrates the heavy-civil contractor pool every yard's projects draw on. The submarine industrial base got \$76.6 billion, which is a labor-market and future-workload event before it is a procurement one. Cold spray became an organic Navy capability, which turns a scrap decision into a routing decision. And a distributed manufacturing network ran a full request-to-delivery cycle at RIMPAC, which is a watch item for forward repair rather than anything to act on yet. Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged.

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

A \$30 billion ceiling at Puget Sound, and what it does to everyone else's program

FACT: Military Times reported on July 22, 2026 that the Navy has published a Sources Sought notice for a multiple-award construction contract worth up to \$30 billion for a Multi-Mission Dry Dock at Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility, part of the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program, running five years plus three one-year options. FACT: the notice, quoted in that

report, describes the dock as “a fully pressure-relieved dry dock capable of accommodating shipyard repair services for the newest Ford-class aircraft carrier, Nimitz-class carriers, and other surface and subsurface ships served by PSNS & IMF.” FACT: the same report quotes the Navy's Multi-Mission Dry Dock website stating that “the Navy does not currently have the capacity and capability to perform depot-level maintenance on a Gerald R. Ford-class carrier in the Pacific Northwest,” and that “the only dry dock on the West Coast able to accommodate a current Nimitz-class aircraft carrier is Dry Dock 6 (DD6), which does not meet seismic resiliency standards and cannot fully accommodate Ford-class carriers.” FACT: Military Times reports the work sits within existing Dry Dock 3 and Piers 6 and 7, that task orders typically range between \$2 billion and \$6 billion each, and that the first task order is expected to cover dredging plus work on piers, buildings and utilities, the second the demolition of Dry Dock 3 and construction of the new dock, and the third infrastructure such as electrical substations, utility tunnels and buildings.

FACT: as dated context, GAO reported on June 28, 2023 (GAO-23-106067) that the estimated cost of the Navy's dry dock project at Portsmouth Naval Shipyard rose from \$528 million to \$2.2 billion between 2019 and 2021, that the Navy had trouble estimating project costs partly because estimates were based on preliminary rather than mature designs, and recommended the Navy update its estimates throughout the design process.

Assessment: three planning consequences follow, and only the first belongs to Puget Sound. For PSNS & IMF this is major

construction inside a working yard: demolishing Dry Dock 3 and reworking Piers 6 and 7 removes docking and berthing capacity for the duration, and dredging and utility work constrains the waterfront around it, so the availability plan for the execution window is a steering committee problem now rather than a NAVFAC one later. For the other three yards, a \$30 billion ceiling with task orders of \$2 billion to \$6 billion concentrates the heavy-civil contractor pool and the NAVFAC execution capacity that your own projects bid against; scarcity of qualified constructors, not scarcity of authorization, is the near-term risk to your schedules. And the GAO finding is the precedent to hold this against: a project scoped from preliminary design at Portsmouth grew roughly fourfold, so the question to put to each task order is what design maturity its estimate rests on.

For SRF-JRMC the stated gap is the one to track: if there is no Pacific Northwest depot capability for Ford-class carriers until this dock exists, then Ford-class presence in the Western Pacific is supported by East Coast docking and by whatever intermediate-level work can be done forward, and that assumption should be visible in your capacity plan rather than implicit in it.

Bottom line: Ask two questions early. What design maturity backs each task order estimate, and which regional constructors will be consumed by this program in the years your own SIOP projects need them.

Sources: Military Times, Jul 22, 2026; GAO-23-106067, Jun 28, 2023

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

\$76.6 billion in submarines is a labor and workload forecast, not a procurement story

FACT: USNI News reported on July 29, 2026 that the Navy awarded General Dynamics Electric Boat and HII \$76.6 billion for the

next batch of attack and ballistic missile submarines after a delay of nearly three years, split into \$42.1 billion for nine Block VI Virginia-class boats plus material for a tenth, \$29.5 billion for five Build II Columbia-class boats, and \$5 billion for workforce improvements between Electric Boat and HII. FACT: USNI reports the July 29 Pentagon announcement states the Block VI award includes previously announced material awards, including long-lead-time and economic ordering quantity material, and previously awarded investments in shipbuilder productivity efforts. FACT: USNI reports the delay traces to a 2022 indemnification dispute that stalled negotiations for 18 months, after which the Navy and the builders struggled for years over workforce wages that rose during the pandemic inflation spike, and that a major factor in rising prices is workforce shortage, with many experienced shipbuilders having retired and the builders competing for labor against other industries. FACT: Electric Boat president Mark Rayha is quoted saying the modifications give the company and its suppliers “the demand certainty we need to continue investing in capacity and hiring the workforce necessary to ensure we deliver these important national security assets on schedule.”

FACT: as dated context, GAO reported in March 2025 that private companies augment the repair work conducted at the Navy’s public shipyards, that the shipbuilding industrial base has not historically met the Navy’s goals, and that while ship repair has improved since 2019, representatives from some companies told GAO they often had more capacity than the Navy used.

Assessment: read the award as three forecasts. On labor, \$5 billion aimed explicitly at workforce lands at two builders who recruit from regional trades markets that public yards also recruit from, and a company president saying the money buys hiring is a statement that wage and hiring

pressure in those markets is about to increase; your retention assumptions for the next two hiring cycles should be tested against that rather than against your own attrition history. On workload, nine attack boats and five ballistic missile boats are hulls that enter a depot cycle years from now, so the planning artifact that matters to a public yard is the delivery schedule behind this award, not its dollar value. On supply, the award explicitly consumes long-lead and economic ordering quantity material, which is vendor capacity your availabilities draw on from the same base. The GAO context cuts the other way and is worth holding: if private repair capacity has at times exceeded what the Navy used, then the constraint in the system is not uniformly capacity, and a workload argument built only on scarcity will not survive scrutiny.

Bottom line: Get the delivery schedule, not the award value, into your long-range workload model, and open the planning-yard and builder relationships for these classes now, because the engineering and technical data you will need arrive on their timeline rather than yours.

Sources: USNI News, Jul 29, 2026; GAO report on naval shipbuilding and ship repair, via USNI News, Mar 4, 2025

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

Cold spray goes organic, and an obsolete part gets printed

FACT: NAVSEA reported on July 16, 2026 that Naval Surface Warfare Center, Crane Division opened its Metal Additive Manufacturing (MADMAN) Repair Center, using low-pressure and high-pressure cold spray to extend the life of naval components. FACT: NSWC Crane Commanding Officer Capt. Rex Boonyobhas is quoted calling it “the first organic industrial base facility for non-structural cold spray within the Navy” and saying it “allows us to shift our focus from ‘replace’ to ‘repair’.” FACT: the release

states cold spray is a solid-state process that projects metal powder at high speed using compressed gas, and that because it does not rely on thermal melting it avoids the cracking and loss of strength that fusion welding can introduce, and that the low-pressure systems are portable enough to project repair capability to the component.

FACT: NAVSEA’s Philadelphia division reported on June 11, 2026 that its engineers are using additive manufacturing to redesign and produce the wallbox for the Boiler Combustion Monitoring System, because the existing part is obsolete and no longer available through traditional supply channels. FACT: the release states the system is installed on the Navy’s six Wasp-class amphibious assault ships and on USS Blue Ridge (LCC 19), the Seventh Fleet flagship, and describes its safety function: the wallbox gives the furnace camera and inspection light a protected path into the boiler furnace, and boiler operators use that view to check the furnace deck for unburned fuel before lighting the burners, because if a burner flame goes out, fuel oil can build on the hot furnace floor, vaporize, and create a potentially explosive situation.

Assessment: both items convert an engineering fact into a business decision. Crane turns a condemnation into a routing question: components your yards currently scrap or send to a vendor because fusion welding would risk them now have an organic path, and the committee-level choice is whether to route candidate parts there, negotiate throughput, or pursue the capability locally. The Philadelphia item is the model for obsolescence: the path to a printed replacement ran through the in-service engineering agent, not a print shop, which means the constraint on your own obsolescence list is engineering authority and qualification rather than machine availability. For SRF-JRMC the hull list is the

direct read, because the flagship it lives with is on it.

Bottom line: Two asks. Send NSWC Crane a candidate parts list from your condemnation data and find out what their intake and throughput actually look like, and route your top obsolescence drivers to the cognizant in-service engineering agent rather than to a printer.

Sources: NAVSEA, Jul 16, 2026; NAVSEA, Jun 11, 2026

OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE & READINESS

A full request-to-delivery cycle ran at RIMPAC, on exercise equipment

FACT: the Navy reported on July 21, 2026 that the Naval Postgraduate School's Consortium for Advanced Manufacturing Research and Education (CAMRE) and FLEETWERX demonstrated a chain during RIMPAC 2026 in which Marines manufactured replacement parts aboard ship using expeditionary advanced manufacturing equipment, a digitally crewed surface vessel carried those components to a US Navy ship, and the delivery completed what the release calls the Department of the Navy's first digitally crewed resupply, after which the same vessel carried drone components to the 25th Infantry Division's Lightning Lab for assembly and testing at Makua Range. FACT: the Navy credits the workflow to the Joint Advanced Manufacturing System, a digital command and control platform developed through CAMRE with the Marine Innovation Unit, which tracks manufacturing requests and assigns production across distributed nodes while cataloging equipment, expertise and production capacity across the enterprise. FACT: in a July 7, 2026 release the Navy said CAMRE was preparing what organizers describe as the largest advanced manufacturing demonstration ever conducted by the Department of War, and

that RIMPAC 2026 involves 35 nations, roughly 40 surface ships, five submarines, more than 140 aircraft and 25,000 personnel.

Assessment: this is a watch item, not an action item, and the distinction matters because the equipment was expeditionary and the setting was an exercise, so nothing here has been through a yard's production or qualification system. What makes it worth a committee's attention is the catalog: a network that inventories production capacity and assigns work across nodes is, if it matures, an allocation mechanism that could route work to or around a repair activity. The questions that decide whether a forward yard becomes a node are qualification authority and who owns the technical data package, and neither is answered by a successful demonstration.

Bottom line: Track JAMS rather than the demonstration, and specifically whether its catalog ever extends to organic industrial-base shops, because that is the point at which this becomes a workload question instead of a technology story.

Sources: Navy.mil, Jul 21, 2026; Navy.mil, Jul 7, 2026

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from NAVSEA releases, USNI News, Naval News, GAO and congressional records, defense.gov, RAND, Defense News, Breaking Defense, The Maritime Executive, NSRP, ASNE, SNAME, arXiv, and academic publishers (18 sources staged this week; 14 quarantined as stale, including a SIOP story a search engine dated to this month that its own page dates to September 2024), then synthesized and labeled by hand. Written for the executive steering committees at the four public shipyards and SRF-JRMC: the test for inclusion is whether an item changes a strategic or business planning assumption. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and INDOPACOM partners. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old and this issue's anchors are all from the last six weeks; older material appears only as clearly dated context. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it; Assessment is analysis built only on facts stated above it. Corrections welcome; the staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Generated from the events registry, nearest first, filling the page (dates and registration deadlines exactly as organizers publish them). **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Aug 18-19, 2026	NSRP Electrical Technologies Panel Meeting, Pullman, WA (also virtual)	None published (Cvent link open)	The panel behind the fiber-optic switchboard-sensing pilot; electrical condition-monitoring tech transfer
Aug 24-25, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance Panel Meeting, Pensacola, FL	In-person closes Aug 13, 2026	Cross-yard workforce practices against the Navy's 250,000-hire target
Sep 22-24, 2026	Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium (FMMS) 2026, Virginia Beach, VA (ASNE)	Early bird thru Aug 16, 2026	The flagship fleet-maintenance event for exactly this readership
Sep 29 - Oct 2, 2026	SCA Fall Membership Meeting 2026, Washington, DC	Members only; none published	The surface-repair industrial base's Hill-and-Navy engagement window
Oct 28-29, 2026	Arctic Operations Symposium 2026, Baltimore, MD (ASNE)	Not published yet	Cold-region sustainment, hull and machinery readiness
Nov 16-17, 2026	Navy Procurement Outlook Summit, Reston, VA (Defense Leadership Forum)	Eventbrite open; no deadline published	Shipbuilding-plan and VCM-era procurement priorities, with contracting-officer access
Dec 7-9, 2026	TSS/CSS Symposium, Arlington, VA (ASNE)	Not published yet	Technology, systems and ships exchange near the NAVSEA customer
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL	Tiers: Jul 31 / Oct 2 / Dec 4; closes Jan 22	Metal and polymer print qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027	"Coming soon" per NSRP	Where yard R&D ideas get socialized and teamed program-wide

Beyond the printed window: Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition (Nov 2-4, 2027). Two AM-lane events sit on the registry without published dates and will print when the organizers set them: the annual ATDM and AM CoE Summit in Danville, and the next Defense Manufacturing Conference.